



A necessary change: Virat Kohli's strategy has shifted from rotating the strike against spin to looking for boundary options. EMMANUEL YOGINI

strike rate of 117 in his last seven outings, with a dot ball percentage of over 50. He was dismissed inside the first six overs in five of the last seven innings. His loss of form will be a concern for the Men in Blue.

But it's not all doom and gloom. **Suryakumar Yadav, India's flamboyant No. 4, returned for Mumbai Indians from an injury layoff to hit three fifties and a century in 11 innings.** Virat Kohli, who will play his sixth T20 World Cup, also went past 9000 runs in T20 cricket on Indian soil in the must-win game against Chennai Super Kings, making him the first player with 9000-plus T20 runs in any country. Kohli has tried to be the PowerPlay enforcer for his team, the Royal Challengers Bengaluru, hitting 33 fours and 20 sixes while striking north of 160 in that phase.

RCB has reaped the rewards of one key Kohli evolution, and India would hope for more of the same. The sweep has been a key scoring option for Kohli to counter spin in

the middle overs this IPL. Essentially, it appears that Kohli's strategy has shifted from rotating the strike against spin to looking for boundary options. It was on full display during his unbeaten 70 off 44 against Gujarat Titans in a league match, where he employed the slog-sweep and the conventional sweep with gay abandon.

"I've brought out the slog-sweep to the spinners. I just mentally put myself in that situation, and I didn't practise it at all," Kohli had said about the change in approach.

"I know I can hit it because I've hit it a lot in the past. So, I just felt like I needed to take a bit more risk, and for me, that shot was something that I used to hit regularly back in the day. **And that's allowing me to hit off the back foot as well, because I'm always looking to expose that side of the field against the spin.**

"For me, that has been a massive factor in this IPL. So, I think it just takes a bit more conviction to take out that thought that props up: 'what

if you get out'. I've been managing to stay ahead of that thought in this IPL, and that's really helped me in the middle overs in this IPL, keeping my strike rate up and keeping the scoring rate going for the team as well." **The realisation that T20 matches aren't about absorbing pressure and attacking on the break, at least not all the time, is timely.** Going into the bunker is never the solution. In the top three, there must also be an attacking threat, ideally initiated by somebody with a wide palette of shots. Kohli has been rightly criticised for letting the ball drop after the PowerPlay in the past, but this current version of him does fit the bill in more ways than one.

The selectors also deserve credit for picking Shivam Dube while his stocks are high. Chennai Super Kings used Dube as a specialist against spin. His strike rate of 155.54 against spin is a direct result of his big reach, power, and clear intent. Dube, though, has a discernible weakness against pace, especially well-directed